chose to march out from his well-provisioned fortress many months later, at the onset of the spring thaw.

While Macnaghten was quietly sacrificing Shah Shuja, Lord Auckland was, somewhat unexpectedly, entertaining Shuja's old rival, Dost Mohammad, at a ball in Calcutta.

After the 'bracing' air of Simla, the Edens were appalled by the heat and humidity of a Calcutta summer. 'We have subsided from the interests of Afghan politics', wrote Emily to a friend, 'into the daily difficulties of keeping ourselves from being baked alive. I may say we have risen to this higher pursuit, for it is much the more important of the two, and of much more difficult achievement?. . .'[104] The heat confirmed her in her opinion that it was time for them all to get out of the horrors of Asia and head quickly back to the safety of Kensington: 'Our George has done very well in India, has he not? You know we always thought very highly of him even in his comical dog days . . . Now I think he has done enough, and might as well go home, but none of the people at home will hear of it, and this month's despatches have made me desperate.'[105]

But duty was duty, and on Queen Victoria's birthday, amid the drenching humidity of a Bengali June, 'the most desperate weather ever felt in India', the sisters decided to throw a ball. 'Our Queen's ball was very magnificent,' Emily wrote soon afterwards, 'and as I fondly hope it is our last, I am glad it went off so well. *I wore my diamonds!*' The star guest, on exhibit to all both as a curiosity and as an advertisement for the great successes of Lord Auckland's foreign policy, was the Amir himself. 'We had Dost Mohammad and his sons and suite at the ball,' continued Emily,

> the first time he had ever seen European ladies in their shameless dress; but he did not see the dancing – George took him to another room. He is a very kingly sort of person, and carries off his half-captive, half-lion position with great tact. By way of relieving George part of the evening, I asked him to play at chess, and we played game after game, which was rather a triumph considering native chess is not like ours, and he kept inventing new rules as we went on. If he were not a Dost it was not quite fair.[106]

Afterwards, Emily asked her chess partner if she could make a portrait of him and his followers. He agreed to sit for her pencil, but then, as appalled as she was by the Calcutta humidity, set off back up country to Ludhiana